

A FREE GUIDE FROM GREG MADDOCK

Your First Descent

How to drop into a calm, focused state tonight — no experience, no nonsense, no pocket watch.

Let me guess how you got here. Anxiety, or sleep that won't come, or a confidence that went missing somewhere along the way. You've tried the breathing apps and the advice to "just relax," and it didn't stick. So you're cautiously poking at this strange thing called self-hypnosis, half-expecting it to be nonsense.

Fair. So let me earn a little trust by doing something most of the people in this space won't: actually teaching you a thing that works, for free, right now, with no catch. By the end of this page you will have gone into a light trance and come back out, under your own power. That's not a metaphor. That's the actual exercise.

First, the two fears, defused

Two worries stop most people from trying this, and both are ghosts.

"What if I lose control?" You won't, because you can't. This isn't mind control and it isn't a drug. In self-hypnosis you are the only person in the room. If your brain decided it didn't like where things were going, it would simply open your eyes. You are always at the wheel. You are, in fact, the entire car.

"What if I get stuck under?" Impossible. Not unlikely — impossible. The worst thing that can happen is the relaxation tips over into an ordinary nap, and then you wake up from the nap, like you've done every day of your life. Trance is not a trap door. It's a comfortable chair you can stand up from whenever you like.

What this actually feels like

Here's the thing that trips up nearly every beginner, so let me say it plainly: trance does not feel like much. Especially at first. It feels like being pleasantly relaxed with your eyes closed. That's it. That's the feeling.

You've probably been waiting to get *knocked out* — some dramatic moment where everything goes swirly and you cross over. That's not how it works. Nobody gets knocked out. You'll most likely finish thinking "well, I was just sitting there relaxed, I don't think anything happened," and you'll be wrong, because

that relaxed, slightly floaty, who-cares-about-my-to-do-list feeling *is* the thing. You were looking for a door and you were already standing in the next room.

The setup (it's almost nothing)

You don't need candles, incense, a singing bowl, or a \$90 weighted eye pillow. You need a spot where you won't be interrupted for about fifteen minutes and a position you can hold comfortably without falling straight asleep.

A comfortable chair is ideal — lying flat in bed is a one-way ticket to actual sleep for a lot of beginners, which is lovely but isn't practice. Put your phone on do not disturb. Loosen anything tight. That's the whole setup.

One quick safety note

Never do this while driving or doing anything that needs your attention. Pick somewhere a surprise nap would be no problem. Obvious, but it needs saying, because relaxation recordings and steering wheels are a genuinely bad mix.

How to use the script below

Here's the one awkward problem nobody warns you about: you can't read a script and be in trance at the same time. The moment you crack an eye to find your place on the page, you're back in the room doing homework. So pick one of two ways before you start.

Record it. Read the script below into your phone's voice recorder, slowly — more slowly than feels natural — with easy pauses, in a calm voice. Then lie back, close your eyes, and let your own voice walk you down. It feels strange to hear yourself for about a minute. You get over it. For a first time, this is by far the easiest way in.

Or learn its shape. Read it through a few times until you've got the order of the steps, then close your eyes and walk yourself through it from memory, freestyling the words. The exact wording never matters as much as the sequence and the feeling.

The Body Scan Script

Settle into your spot. There's nothing to achieve here and no way to fail. You're just going to relax, on purpose, with a little structure. Begin when you're ready.

BEGIN SCRIPT

Get comfortable, and let your eyes gently close. There is nothing you need to do for the next little while except let go. No problem to solve, nowhere to be. Just this.

Start by taking a slow breath in... and let it out, slowly, like a long sigh at the end of a long day. And again, breathe in... and let it go. With each breath out, you can let yourself settle just a little more, sinking gently into the chair, letting it hold all of your weight.

Now bring your attention all the way up to the top of your head. Just notice it. And let any tightness in your scalp and your forehead simply melt, softening, letting go. Let it spread down into your face... your jaw unclenching, the little muscles around your eyes going soft and still.

Let that softness flow down into your neck and your shoulders. And just let your shoulders drop. Most of us carry the whole day up there. Let them come down now, heavy and loose, all that holding simply draining away.

Let the relaxation move down your arms... upper arms, elbows, forearms, all the way to your hands and fingers. Let them grow heavy and warm and still, so relaxed they feel almost too heavy to lift — and you have no reason to lift them.

And let it sink into your chest and your back, your breathing slow and easy now, all on its own. Down into your stomach, letting it soften. Any place that has been held tight all day can let go now. There is nothing to brace against here.

Let the heaviness flow down through your hips, and your legs... your thighs, your knees, down through your calves, all that weight settling. All the way down to your feet, to the very tips of your toes. Your whole body, from the top of your head to the soles of your feet, soft, heavy, and at ease.

And just rest here for a moment. Notice how it feels. Calm. Quiet. Pleasantly heavy. Maybe a little floaty. This is it. This is the state. You are doing it exactly right. Stay here, breathing easily, for as long as feels good.

(Rest here a minute or two. When you are ready to come up, continue.)

In a moment I am going to count from one to five, and as I do, you will come back up, feeling calm, clear, and refreshed, as though you have just had a wonderful rest. One... beginning to come back, awareness returning to the room. Two... energy flowing back into your arms and legs. Three... feeling clearer, lighter. Four... almost all the way back now, ready to open your eyes. And five... eyes open, fully awake, calm and refreshed.

END SCRIPT

So what was that?

That calm, heavy, slightly removed feeling where your to-do list got quieter and time went a little wobbly — that was trance. If your reaction is “that’s it? I was basically just relaxed,” then congratulations, you understood it perfectly and you’re exactly where you’re supposed to be.

And if your mind wandered the whole time? Also completely normal, and not a failure. Minds wander. The skill isn’t preventing it — it’s gently bringing your attention back when you notice, without giving yourself a hard time. Every time you notice you drifted and come back, *that* is the rep. You didn’t do it wrong. That is literally the exercise.

A few notes to settle in

Practice this one on its own for a few days before reaching for anything fancier. It’s the foundation everything else stands on. Go at your own speed — linger where you like, speed up where you don’t. And don’t strain toward some “deeper” trance you imagine you’re missing; straining is the opposite of the whole activity. Whatever level of relaxed you reach is the right level for today.

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That’s your first descent. You found the door, walked through it, and came back — and now you know the great anticlimactic secret: going under feels like settling into a comfortable chair and letting the day fall off your shoulders. No swirling vortex. No lost time. Just you, calmer, with the lights turned low.

This is one piece of a full self-hypnosis course I’ve been building — a hands-on guide to using this stuff for anxiety, sleep, confidence, and the rest of it, written by someone who needed it badly and found it genuinely worked. It’s called *Nobody Gets Knocked Out*, and it’s coming soon. If this was useful, you’ll be the first to know when it’s ready.

For now — go find a quiet chair. You’ve got everything you need for tonight.